



M3 Stuart

As World War II drew near, the US military set about replacing its outdated M2 light tank with a newer, better-armored version. The M3 was armed with a 37 mm M6 main gun supported by five machine guns, later reduced to two; its armor and weapons were no match for most tanks, but it was well-liked for its speed and mechanical performance.

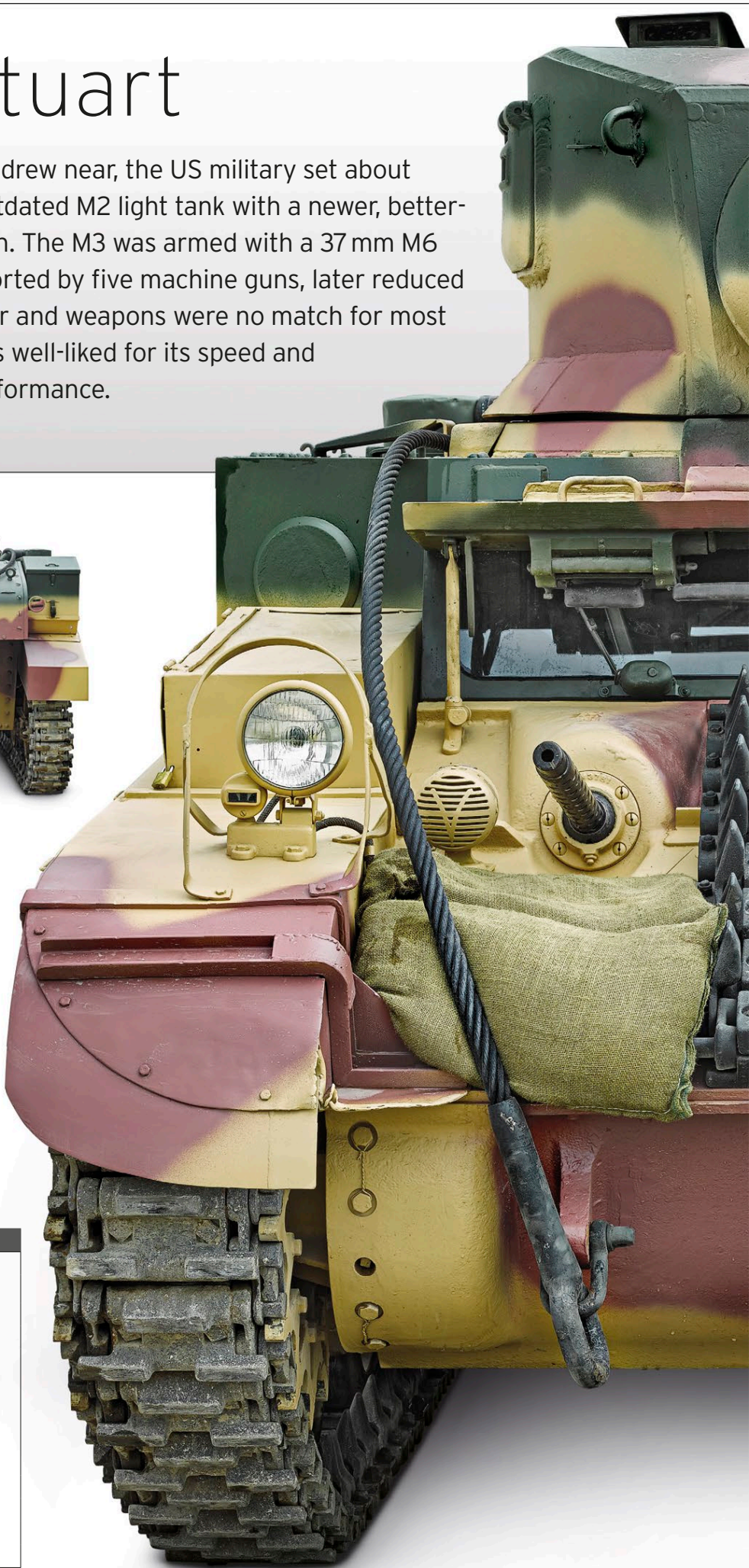
USED BY BOTH BRITISH and US armed forces, the M3 was christened “Stuart” after the Confederate General J. E. B. Stuart, in keeping with the British military tradition that named US-made tanks after US generals. Later, British troops gave it the affectionate nickname “honey” in honor of its reliability.

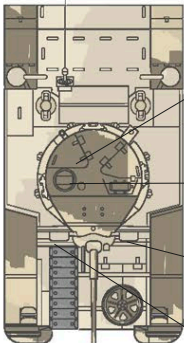
The M3 had a Continental air-cooled radial engine with a heavy fuel consumption. This affected its operational range, which could be as low as 75 miles (120 km) before refueling was necessary. However, British troops liked the reliability of the tank, and even though many Stuarts were knocked out in early encounters in the North African desert, this was mainly due to poor tactical use, not through any particular fault of the vehicles themselves.

An improved model of the tank—the M5, with a redesigned hull and Cadillac V-8 engine—began replacing earlier models of the M3 from 1943 (see p.84). However, by this time it was clear that the 37 mm gun was inadequate as an antitank gun against the heavier vehicles in use in Europe. The M3 and M5 were still used for reconnaissance in British service, sometimes with turrets removed for speed, and the tank was still a match for the less well-protected Japanese armored vehicles in the Pacific theater of war.



REAR VIEW



SPECIFICATIONS		
Name	M3A1 Stuart	
Date	1941	
Origin	USA	
Production	22,700	
Engine	Continental R-670 7-cylinder gasoline, 250hp	
Weight	14.2 tons (12.9 tonnes)	
Main armament	37 mm M6	
Secondary armament	.30 Browning M1919	
Crew	4	
Armor thickness	2 in (51mm) max	